Two Brains: how to run it

Claude in the cloud plus Qwen on your Mac, with automatic fallback. Open Terminal and use the commands below.

1. Pick your mode

I want	Run	Who answers	Private?
Plain Claude, exactly as before	`claude`	Claude only. No local models at all.	No
Plain Claude, leaner start (no claude.ai connectors)	`claude-lean`	Claude only. About 11K fewer input tokens per session in our test.	No
Claude plus local models, with automatic fallback (the full setup)	`claude-local`	Claude. It hands bulk chores to Qwen 9B and takes over if Qwen fails.	No Claude sees everything
Local model, Claude Code style (offline agent)	`claude-private`	Qwen 9B only	Yes nothing leaves the Mac
Local model, plain chat	`ollama run qwen3.5:9b-64k`	Qwen only, no files, no tools	Yes

2. Claude plus local models: `claude-local` (with fallback)

Go to your project folder and run `claude-local`. It opens Claude Code with the local helper and the delegation rules loaded. Plain `claude` never has them.

```
cd ~/your-project
claude-local
```

How it behaves:

- Bulk chores (summaries, sorting, extracting, boilerplate) go to Qwen 9B. Claude reviews the result and adds a note like *(local 9B: summarize, 7s)*.
- Hard thinking stays with Claude.
- If Qwen fails (timeout, out of memory, Ollama off, empty answer), Claude does the job itself and says so in one line. You do nothing.

> **Force a side, any time** (inside `claude-local`)
> Add **claude only** to a request: no local model is used.
> Add **local only** to a request: only the local model does the work, and Claude stops if it fails (still not private, Claude sees the text).
> Per project: put `Delegation: off` or `Delegation: prefer` in that project's `CLAUDE.md`.

Offload reading on big jobs (measure it, savings are not guaranteed): ask per file (*"one sentence on what each .py file in src/ does"*). The local model then reads the files inside the project folder (never secrets like .env) and Claude only sees the short result. Compare real token use with `ai-stats sessions`; no new line in `bridge/bridge.log` means Claude did it alone.

3. Private work: `claude-private`

The Claude Code screen with Qwen 9B as the brain, running on your Mac. Works with Wi-Fi off. Use it for anything sensitive.

```
cd ~/your-project
claude-private
```

> **Why this mode exists:** with `claude` and `claude-local`, what you type and what Claude reads goes to Anthropic's servers. For client or sensitive data that is not acceptable. `claude-private` sends everything to Qwen on your Mac instead, so nothing leaves the machine.
> **Why the 9B and not the 27B:** Claude Code needs a large memory window (about 64K tokens) because it reads files and tool instructions. The 9B runs that comfortably (7.7 GB loaded). The 27B uses 18 GB of your 24 GB and crashed with out of memory errors on large inputs, which is exactly what an agent produces. Use the 27B only for short questions in a plain `ollama run` chat.
> **Tradeoff:** far less capable than Claude. Use it when privacy matters more than quality.

- Ollama starts by itself if it is closed (give it a few seconds).
- It asks before running commands or editing files. Press **Shift+Tab** to accept edits. Do not use auto mode (it needs the internet).
- No connectors and no MCP servers are loaded, so it cannot reach the internet.
- It is slower and less capable than Claude. Give it small, specific tasks and review its code.

4. Plain local chat: Qwen only

No Claude, no Claude Code. A chat with the model, nothing else.

```
ollama run qwen3.5:9b-64k          # everyday, long inputs
ollama run qwen3.8:27b-mlx         # harder questions, SHORT inputs only
```

Type your question and press Enter. Leave with **/bye**. Keep the 27B for short questions only. You can also use the chat window in the Ollama app (pick a model with no cloud icon).

5. Memory and housekeeping

Command	What it does
`ai-status`	Shows installed models and what is loaded in memory
`ai-stop`	Unloads every model to free RAM (only one model stays loaded at a time)
`ai-stats`	Local model stats. `ai-stats sessions` shows Claude's exact token use per session.
`/exit`	Leave any Claude session (`claude`, `claude-local`, `claude-private`)
`/bye`	Leave an `ollama run` chat

6. Why `ollama list` shows three names but you have two models

Name	What it is
`qwen3.5:9b`	The 9B model as downloaded
`qwen3.5:9b-64k`	The **same** 9B with a bigger memory window (64K), needed by Claude Code. It points at the same downloaded files, so it uses no extra disk space.
`qwen3.8:27b-mlx`	The larger 27B model for hard, short questions

The 7.6 GB repeats in the list but is stored once. Keep both 9B names: the installer builds the 64K one from the base.

7. If something goes wrong (more in docs/troubleshooting.md)

Symptom	Fix
Ollama commands hang or "timed out waiting for server"	`open -a Ollama`, wait a few seconds
Memory setting shows "not set" after a restart	Quit Ollama from the menu bar, reopen it with `open -a Ollama`
"Insufficient Memory" crash	Input too big for the model. Use the 9B or split the input. No restart needed.